



City of Cambridge

POR 2026-133
FIRST IN COUNCIL
August 3, 2026

COUNCILLOR SIMMONS
COUNCILLOR MCGOVERN
MAYOR SIDDIQUI

- WHEREAS: The 2026 Cambridge Dance Party, held on June 26, 2026 in Central Square, was a tremendous success and once again demonstrated the power of joyful, inclusive public programming to bring residents, families, workers, students, visitors, artists, and local businesses together in the heart of the city; and
- WHEREAS: The Cambridge Dance Party has become one of the City's signature civic celebrations and serves as an unofficial kickoff to summer in Cambridge, filling Massachusetts Avenue with music, dancing, community spirit, and civic pride; and
- WHEREAS: From 1993 through 2005, the Central Square World's Fair similarly served as one of Cambridge's signature community festivals, bringing thousands of people to Massachusetts Avenue and nearby side streets for food, music, crafts, performances, community booths, family activities, and a broad celebration of Central Square's diversity, creativity, entrepreneurial spirit, and cultural life; and
- WHEREAS: For more than a decade, the Central Square World's Fair transformed the heart of Cambridge into a vibrant gathering place, generating economic activity for local businesses while showcasing the City's commitment to inclusion, civic engagement, arts, culture, and community; and
- WHEREAS: Central Square remains one of the Commonwealth's most diverse commercial districts and is home to the state-designated Central Square Cultural District, which celebrates arts, culture, innovation, and the many communities that call Cambridge home; and
- WHEREAS: The City of Cambridge, Cambridge Arts, the City's Arts and Culture Division, the Central Square Business Improvement District, local businesses, residents, artists, and community partners have demonstrated the ability to successfully produce large-scale public events in Central Square that strengthen community, support local businesses, and celebrate Cambridge's unique identity; and
- WHEREAS: Reviving the Central Square World's Fair would honor the legacy of the original festival while supporting today's goals of strengthening local restaurants and retailers, uplifting artists and cultural organizations, activating public space, creating opportunities for intercultural exchange, and celebrating the many communities that make Cambridge unique, while also serving as a natural September bookend to the summer season alongside the Cambridge Dance Party; now therefore be it

- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to work with Cambridge Arts, the City's Arts and Culture Division, the Central Square Business Improvement District, relevant City departments, neighborhood organizations, local businesses, artists, residents, and other community partners to explore and plan for the revival of the Central Square World's Fair in September 2027; and be it further
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to consider the revived Central Square World's Fair as a major multicultural street festival celebrating the food, music, art, small businesses, cultural traditions, innovation, entrepreneurship, educational institutions, community organizations, and civic life of Central Square and Cambridge as a whole; and be it further
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to examine how a revived Central Square World's Fair could build upon the successful partnership between the City, Cambridge Arts, and the Central Square Business Improvement District, including lessons learned from the annual Cambridge Dance Party and other large-scale public events; and be it further
- ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council with an initial feasibility update no later than December 31, 2026, including possible event models, governance structure, estimated costs, potential funding sources, recommended City and community partners, community engagement opportunities, programming concepts, permitting needs, public safety coordination, logistical considerations, and an implementation timeline for launching the revived Central Square World's Fair in September 2027.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-



Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to examine how a revived Central Square World's Fair could build upon the successful partnership between the City, Cambridge Arts, and the Central Square Business Improvement District, including lessons learned from the annual Cambridge Dance Party and other large-scale public events.